

NELSON MANDELA

1956

Mandela is arrested (along with other members of the ANC) and charged with “high treason” for betraying the government. He is found not guilty in 1961.

1962

Mandela is arrested and sentenced to five years in prison for urging South African workers to go on strike and for leaving the country without a passport.

1964

On June 12, Mandela and seven others are convicted and sentenced to life in prison for plotting to overthrow the government. Mandela is sent to Robben Island prison.

1990

Following calls from around the world to “free Nelson Mandela,” on February 11—after spending 27 years in prison—Mandela is finally released at the age of 71. He becomes president of the ANC in 1991.



1993

Mandela works with the president of South Africa, F. W. de Klerk, to put an end to apartheid and introduce equal rights for all South Africans. The pair are awarded a Nobel Peace Prize.

1994

All South Africans are allowed to vote for the first time ever in the general election. Mandela's ANC party wins the election and Mandela becomes the first Black president of South Africa on May 10.

SOWETO UPRISING

On June 16, 1976, thousands of Black students came together in Soweto to protest about a new law that said all pupils must learn Afrikaans in school. They were brutally attacked by police and many were killed in what became known as the “Soweto uprising.”

